

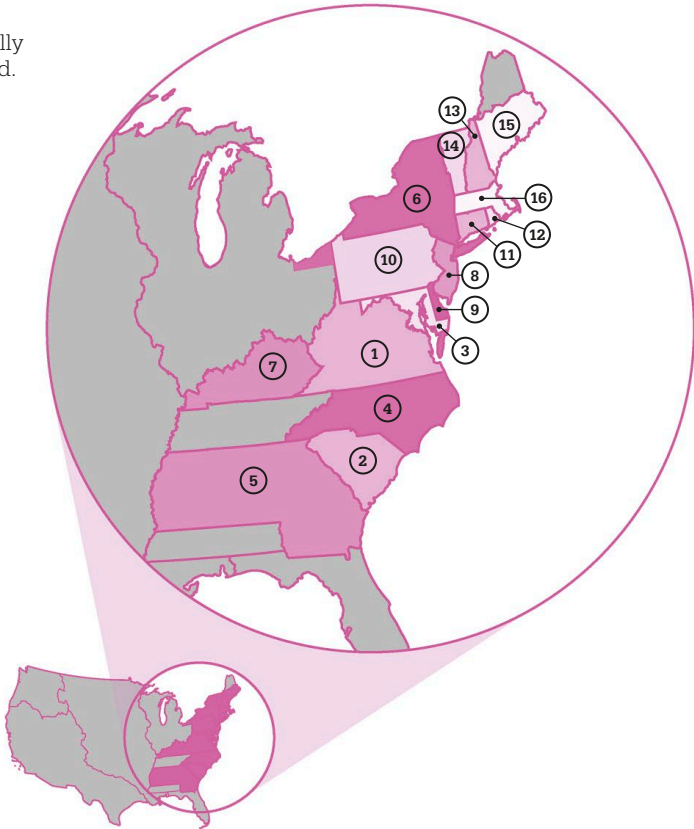
See also: The US Constitution and Bill of Rights 110–117 ■ The Declaration of the Rights of Man 118–119 ■ The Abolition of the Slave Trade Act 132–139 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229 ■ The Civil Rights Act 248–253

Slaves in the US in 1790

The US held its first national census in 1790. The population was counted in all 13 states, plus the districts of Kentucky, Maine, and Vermont. “Slaves” were listed separately from “free white males” and “free white females.” No slaves were counted in Massachusetts or Maine, which had unofficially abolished slavery. By 1840, the slave population had tripled.

State/district	Slaves	Slaves as % of state population
1. Virginia	292,627	39%
2. South Carolina	107,094	43%
3. Maryland	103,036	32%
4. North Carolina	100,572	26%
5. Georgia	29,264	35%
6. New York	21,324	6%
7. Kentucky	12,430	17%
8. New Jersey	11,423	6%
9. Delaware	8,887	15%
10. Pennsylvania	3,737	<1%
11. Connecticut	2,764	1%
12. Rhode Island	948	1%
13. New Hampshire	158	<1%
14. Vermont	16	<1%
15. Maine	0	0%
16. Massachusetts	0	0%

Total US population	3,893,635
Slave population in US	695,280
Percentage of slaves in US	18%



which could not be provided by the settlers or the Indigenous population. African slaves had already proved their worth in the South American and West Indian colonies of the Spanish, Dutch, Portuguese, and English, so it followed that they would provide the necessary labor for the new plantations of North America.

In the 17th and 18th centuries, slaves were imported across the southern and eastern North American seaboard, with most

shipped to the South, where they were set to work on plantations. Once the invention of the cotton gin in 1793 transformed the speed with which cotton seeds could be separated from fibers, slaves were tied to the cotton plantations that spread across all Southern states.

Master and slave

Despite enduring backbreaking work and poor conditions, slaves rarely rebelled. The prospect of rebellion, however, terrified the

slaves’ masters, and as slave numbers grew, so the American colonies set up policing rules, or codes, to keep slaves under control. Virginia, the largest slave-owning colony, introduced its first slave statute in 1639, declaring that, “All persons except Negroes are to be provided with arms and ammunitions or be fined.”

In 1661, the English colony of Barbados in the Caribbean went further. Here, newly planted sugar estates were proving highly »